

Google+ update

Google+ notifications have been revamped and now feature device syncing support across multiple platforms. Vic Gundotra himself shared this news on his Google+ profile

**Online Passes no more**

John Reseburg of EA has confirmed that all present and future titles by EA will no longer require an online pass.

A (Solid) State of Storage

Western Digital recently held its Annual Executive Summit in Istanbul where its senior executives about what the storage company is focusing on and why the personal cloud is so important. We caught up with Richard E. Rutledge, Senior Vice President and General Manager, Datacenter Storage, WD and William Cain, Vice President, Technology, WD at the event.

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Q WD as a brand has attained consumer mindshare over the last decade, so much so that people walk into stores with an intent to buy WD branded products. Nowadays, a consumer can store most of his personal data on the public cloud with Google and Facebook. With so much focus on the public and personal cloud, do you think WD as a brand is at risk of disappearing from a consumer's mind?

Rich Rutledge: No, I think we have a good offering in personal cloud which, economically and because of its ease of use, is a fantastic solution. So, we do believe that our presence in the home will remain in the personal cloud but we do admit that the public cloud also offers value to the consumer.

Bill Cain: Well, I hope that WD as a brand will remain very important to the consumer. I agree that the consumer is getting used to the idea of storing data with services like Facebook but it's really not at a point where it can supplant your primary storage. This is because storing all your personal data on the public cloud is not very economical, since most of these services cost money and moving that data around is an arduous process. Relying on the personal cloud inside a home is also very economical because you can just buy one storage device that meets your needs and there are no monthly charges associated with it. So, we'd actually like to create more of a brand awareness with respect to our personal cloud storage solutions and explain to the consumer how it's different from the public cloud.

Q With the Xbox One and the PlayStation 4 so heavily reliant on the cloud for stream-

ing and storage, isn't that efficiency gap between the public cloud and the private cloud being erased?

Bill Cain: Well, both consoles do have local storage as well. However, if you're somebody shooting a lot of hi-resolution images or videos, you can't really practically store



Bill Cain, VP, Technology, WD

all of that on the cloud. We've talked to a lot of these cloud storage providers and they've told us that consumers are really happy with the first 5GB of free storage but the second tier of paid storage hasn't gathered a lot of traction. So, there's clearly a place for the public cloud but if we're talking about a large amount of personal content, people are more comfortable with having that data under their direct control and it makes much more economic sense to have that data stored locally.

Q Do you see WD targeting the cloud storage service market as competition to companies like Dropbox and Box?

Rich Rutledge: We already provide personal cloud storage solutions to consumers through some of our products. If there is

a business opportunity that would make sense to us to provide some kind of a cloud storage solution to consumers, we'd be ready to do something like that. Our focus is storage solutions and that would fit into that focus area.

Q There are some companies in India who are using cloud technology to reach out to rural areas and also to facilitate education through the cloud. Is WD involved with partners in such projects in India?

Rich Rutledge: It would be easier to use Russia as a proxy for what India will become in the future. Russia has some large local cloud service providers who provide services for both government and personal purposes. The Russian government's e-initiatives are far ahead of the Indian government's and a lot of the storage products in use there come from local integrators who win tenders from the organisations in question. That would be our model for India as well. That's one of the reasons why we have recently hired a new head for our Indian operations with a datacentre intensive background.

Q PC sales have been dropping steadily for some time. As a company associated with the PC, does WD see this as a cyclic trend?

Bill Cain: Obviously, PC market has been flattish to slightly down recently. Now tablets and mobiles are becoming larger and becoming, as some say, mobile PCs. We can't really say if the PC is definitely a declining market but as we recently stated at our earnings call, the PC market constitutes less than half of the total sales that we have. We look at data centres and the cloud as growing markets and also, the personal cloud that will probably supplant desktop growth. Overall, we think the market for storage remains extremely healthy.